Music Genres Guide

A reference guide to the main musical genres, their origins, sound characteristics, subgenres and key artists. Part of the Spotify AI Assistant knowledge base.

1. How to use this guide

This guide describes eight families of genres: Pop, Rock, Hip-Hop, Electronic, Jazz, Classical, R&B/Soul and Latin. For each one it explains where it comes from, what it sounds like, its most important subgenres and a short list of representative artists. Genre labels are useful for discovery, but many modern artists mix several genres, so they should be read as guides rather than strict boxes.

> **Spotify AI Assistant Energy Scale.** To help recommend music for different situations, this project uses its own 1–5 energy scale (1 = very calm, 5 = very intense). The scale is defined by the Spotify AI Assistant project team and is not an official Spotify metric. The value for each genre appears in the summary table in Section 10.

2. Pop

Origins: Pop ("popular music") took shape in the 1950s and 1960s as music designed for a wide audience, radio play and record sales.

Sound: Catchy melodies and hooks, a clear verse–chorus structure, songs usually around three to four minutes long and polished production. Lyrics usually deal with love, relationships, self-confidence and everyday emotions.

Main subgenres

- **Synth-pop:** pop built on synthesizers, born in the late 1970s and 1980s (Depeche Mode, Pet Shop Boys). It returned strongly in the 2020s with songs such as The Weeknd's "Blinding Lights".
- **Dance-pop:** pop designed for dancing, with a steady beat (Madonna, Dua Lipa).
- **Indie pop / alt-pop:** pop with a more personal or experimental production (Lorde, Billie Eilish, Clairo).
- **K-pop:** South Korean pop known for highly produced music, choreography and visuals (BTS, BLACKPINK).

Key artists: Michael Jackson, Madonna, Taylor Swift, Billie Eilish, Dua Lipa, Harry Styles.

3. Rock

Origins: Rock and roll emerged in the United States in the late 1940s and 1950s from blues, rhythm and blues and country. In the 1960s it became "rock" and spread worldwide.

Sound: Electric guitar, bass and drums at the core, often with strong riffs and a band format.

Main subgenres

- **Classic rock:** the big bands of the late 1960s and 1970s (Led Zeppelin, Queen, Fleetwood Mac).
- **Punk:** fast, short and raw songs from the mid-1970s, with a do-it-yourself attitude (Ramones, Sex Pistols, The Clash).

- **Post-punk:** darker and more experimental music that followed punk (Joy Division, The Cure).
- **Grunge:** heavy, distorted rock from Seattle in the late 1980s and early 1990s (Nirvana, Pearl Jam, Soundgarden).
- **Garage rock revival:** early 2000s return to short, raw guitar songs (The Strokes, The White Stripes).
- **Alternative rock** and **indie rock**: explained in detail in Section 4.

4. Indie rock vs. alternative rock

These two labels are often confused because they overlap a lot. The key differences are their origin and, today, their sound and scale.

Aspect	Indie rock	Alternative rock
Origin of the term	"Indie" comes from *independent* record labels, such as Rough Trade, Sub Pop, Matador or Domino.	Started in the 1980s for rock played on US college radio, outside the commercial mainstream.
Industry	Traditionally linked to small labels and a DIY approach.	Became mainstream in the 1990s, especially after Nirvana's *Nevermind* (1991) on a major label.
Typical sound	Jangly or angular guitars, a less polished or lo-fi production, a focus on lyrics and character.	A broader umbrella with bigger production, from melancholic to heavy, often made for large venues.
Examples	Arctic Monkeys (signed to Domino), The Strokes, Vampire Weekend, Pavement.	Radiohead, Coldplay, The Killers, Foo Fighters, Muse.

In short: **alternative rock** is the wider family that grew outside the mainstream and later became very popular, while **indie rock** started as a description of how the music was released (independent labels) and later also came to describe a particular sound. Many bands, such as Arctic Monkeys, are described with both labels.

5. Hip-Hop

Origins: Hip-hop was born in the Bronx (New York) in the 1970s as a culture with four elements: DJing, MCing (rapping), breakdancing and graffiti. Its history is described in the *Music History and Trends* document.

Sound: Rhythmic spoken lyrics (rap) over beats built from samples, drum machines or live instruments.

Main subgenres

- **Boom bap:** classic 1990s East Coast sound with strong drum samples (Nas, A Tribe Called Quest).
- **West Coast / G-funk:** funk-influenced sound from California (Dr. Dre, Snoop Dogg).
- **Conscious hip-hop:** lyrics focused on social and political issues (Kendrick Lamar, Common).
- **Trap:** from the US South (Atlanta), with Roland TR-808 bass and fast hi-hats (T.I., Future, Migos, Travis Scott).
- **Drill:** dark, aggressive style that started in Chicago in the early 2010s and later developed in the UK.

Key artists: Tupac, The Notorious B.I.G., Jay-Z, Eminem, Kanye West, Kendrick Lamar, Drake.

6. Electronic

Origins: Electronic music uses synthesizers, drum machines and computers. Pioneers such as Kraftwerk in the 1970s were followed by the dance music scenes of Chicago and Detroit in the 1980s.

Main subgenres

Subgenre	Origin	Typical tempo	Characteristics	Artists
House	Chicago, mid-1980s	about 115–130 BPM	4/4 beat, soulful vocals, groove	Frankie Knuckles, Daft Punk (French house)
Techno	Detroit, mid-1980s	about 120–140 BPM	Repetitive, machine-like, hypnotic	Juan Atkins, Derrick May, Kevin Saunderson
Drum and bass	UK, 1990s	about 160–180 BPM	Fast breakbeats, heavy basslines	Goldie, Chase & Status
Ambient	UK, 1970s	Free / slow	Atmospheric, no strong beat	Brian Eno, Aphex Twin
EDM (big room / electro house)	Global festivals, 2010s	about 125–130 BPM	Big "drops", made for festivals	Avicii, Calvin Harris, David Guetta

Note: Brian Eno's album *Ambient 1: Music for Airports* (1978) helped name the ambient genre.

7. Jazz

Origins: Jazz developed in New Orleans in the early 20th century, mixing African American musical traditions, blues and ragtime.

Sound: Improvisation, swing rhythm, blue notes and interaction between musicians.

Main subgenres

- **Swing (1930s–40s):** big band music for dancing (Duke Ellington, Count Basie).
- **Bebop (1940s):** fast and complex small-group jazz (Charlie Parker, Dizzy Gillespie).
- **Cool and modal jazz (1950s):** calmer and more spacious. Miles Davis' *Kind of Blue* (1959) is the best-known example.
- **Jazz fusion (late 1960s–70s):** jazz combined with rock and funk (Miles Davis' *Bitches Brew*, Weather Report).
- **Contemporary jazz:** artists who mix jazz with hip-hop and soul (Kamasi Washington, Robert Glasper).

8. Classical

Definition: "Classical music" is used broadly for the Western art music tradition. Strictly speaking, the "Classical period" is only one of its eras.

Period	Approximate dates	Characteristics	Composers
Baroque	c. 1600–1750	Ornamentation, counterpoint, harpsichord	J. S. Bach, Vivaldi, Handel

Period	Approximate dates	Characteristics	Composers
Classical	c. 1750–1820	Balance, clarity, the symphony and sonata	Mozart, Haydn, early Beethoven
Romantic	c. 1820–1900	Emotion, large orchestras, virtuoso piano	Chopin, Tchaikovsky, Brahms
20th century / Impressionism	c. 1890–1950	New harmonies, colour, atmosphere	Debussy, Ravel, Stravinsky
Minimalism and contemporary	1960s–today	Repetition, gradual change, film music	Steve Reich, Philip Glass, Max Richter, Ludovico Einaudi

9. R&B / Soul and Latin

R&B and Soul

"Rhythm and blues" became the industry term in 1949, when Billboard magazine replaced the earlier label "race records". Soul developed in the 1960s around labels such as Motown and Stax (Aretha Franklin, Marvin Gaye, Otis Redding). Contemporary R&B grew in the 1990s (Mary J. Blige, TLC), and in the 2010s **alternative R&B** brought a darker, more atmospheric sound (Frank Ocean, The Weeknd, SZA).

Latin music

- **Reggaeton:** developed in Puerto Rico in the 1990s with the "dembow" rhythm. Daddy Yankee's "Gasolina" (2004) made it international. Current stars include Bad Bunny, Karol G and J Balvin.
- **Flamenco and new flamenco:** a tradition from Andalusia (Spain). Rosalía mixed it with pop, R&B and electronic music on *El mal querer* (2018).
- **Latin pop:** pop sung in Spanish or Portuguese (Shakira, Enrique Iglesias).

10. Summary table and Energy Scale

Genre	Typical mood	Typical tempo	Energy Scale (1–5)	Good for
Pop	Happy, catchy	Medium	4	Commuting, parties
Rock (classic)	Energetic	Medium–fast	4	Road trips, workouts
Indie rock	Cool, nostalgic	Medium	3	Walking, hanging out
Alternative rock	Emotional	Medium	3	Relaxing, rainy days
Hip-Hop / Trap	Confident, intense	Medium	4	Workouts
House / Techno	Euphoric, hypnotic	Fast	5	Parties, running
Ambient	Calm, spacious	Slow / free	1	Studying, sleeping
Jazz	Relaxed, sophisticated	Variable	2	Studying, dinners

Genre	Typical mood	Typical tempo	Energy Scale (1–5)	Good for
Classical (neoclassical)	Calm, emotional	Slow	1	Studying, concentration
R&B / Soul	Smooth, romantic	Slow–medium	2	Relaxing, evenings
Reggaeton	Festive	about 90–100 BPM	5	Parties, dancing